

Chapter four, part two
Topic on the theories of Socialization

Ety Rani
Assistant Professor
Sociology discipline
Khulna University

Theoretical understanding of socialization

The social self

George Herbert Mead

Sociologist George Herbert Mead (1934) maintains that the key to role-taking is self-awareness. According to Mead, people possess self-awareness when they can comprehend their place in social activities going on around them. Mead maintained that we learn to do this through a three-stage interactive process. Those stages are-

- (1) preparatory or imitation stage
- (2) play stage and
- (3) Games stage.

Each stage involves a progressively more sophisticated level of imaginative role-taking.

- **In the imitation stage**, infants can only imitate behavior without really understanding its purposes. If their parents rub their own bellies and laugh, 1-year-olds may do likewise.
- After they reach the age of 3, they are in the **play stage**. Here most of their play is by themselves or with only one or two other children, and much of it involves pretending to be other people: their parents, teachers, superheroes, television characters, and so forth.
- In this stage they begin taking the role of the other. Once they reach age 6 or 7, or roughly the time school begins, the **games stage** begins, and children start playing in team sports and games. The many players in these games perform many kinds of roles, and they must all learn to anticipate the actions of other members of their team. In so doing, they learn what is expected of the roles all team members are supposed to play and by extension begin to understand the roles society wants us to play, or to use Mead's term, the expectations of the generalized other. Mead felt that the self has two parts, the *I* and the *me*. The *I* is the creative, spontaneous part of the self, while the *me* is the more passive part of the self stemming from the internalized expectations of the larger society. These two parts are not at odds, he thought, but instead complement each other and thus enhance the individual's contributions to society. Society needs creativity, but it also needs at least some minimum of conformity. The development of both these parts of the self is important not only for the individual but also for the society to which the individual belongs.

Theoretical understanding of socialization

The social self

Charles Horton Cooley (1864–1929)

Charles Horton Cooley (*Social organization*, 1902) developed his famous concept of the **looking-glass self** to summarize this process. Cooley said we first imagine how we appear to others and then imagine how they think of us and, more specifically, whether they are evaluating us positively or negatively. We then use these perceptions to develop judgments and feelings about ourselves, such as pride or embarrassment.

- Sometimes errors occur in this complex process, as we may misperceive how others regard us and develop misguided judgments of our behavior and feelings. For example, you may have been in a situation where someone laughed at what you said, and you thought they were mocking you, when in fact they just thought you were being funny. Although you should have interpreted their laughter positively, you interpreted it negatively and probably felt stupid or embarrassed.

- Whether errors occur or not, the process Cooley described is especially critical during childhood and adolescence, when we are still in a state of flux. Imagine how much better children on a sports team feel after being cheered for making a great play or how children in the school band feel after a standing ovation at the end of the band's performance. If they feel better about themselves, they may do that much better next time. For better or worse, the reverse is also true. If children do poorly on the sports field or in school performance and the applause they hoped for does not occur, they may feel dejected and worse about themselves and from frustration or anxiety perform worse the next time around.
- Yet it is also true that the looking-glass-self process affects us throughout our lives. By the time we get out of late adolescence and into our early adult years, we have very much developed the conception of ourselves, yet this development is never complete. As young, middle-aged, or older adults, we continue to react to our perceptions of how others view us, and these perceptions influence the conception of ourselves, even if this influence is often less than was true in our younger years. Whether our social interaction is with friends, relatives, coworkers, supervisors, or even strangers, ourselves continue to change.

Cognitive Development

Piaget and Cognitive Development

- Children acquire a self and a personality but they also learn how to think and reason. How they acquire such *cognitive development* was the focus of research by Swiss psychologist Jean Piaget (1896–1980). Piaget(1954)Piaget, J. (1954). *The construction of reality in the child*. New York, NY: Basic Books. thought that cognitive development occurs through four stages and that proper maturation of the brain and socialization were necessary for adequate development.
- The first stage is the ***sensorimotor stage***, in which infants cannot really think or reason and instead use their hearing, vision, and other senses to discover the world around them.
- The second stage is the ***preoperational stage***, lasting from about age 2 to age 7, in which children begin to use symbols, especially words, to understand objects and simple ideas.

Piaget and Cognitive Development

- ❖ The third stage is the ***concrete operational stage***, lasting from about age 7 to age 11 or 12, in which children begin to think in terms of cause and effect but still do not understand underlying principles of fairness, justice, and related concepts.
- ❖ The fourth and final stage is the ***formal operational stage***, which begins about the age of 12. Here children begin to think abstractly and use general principles to resolve various problems. Recent research supports Piaget's emphasis on the importance of the early years for children's cognitive development. Scientists have found that brain activity develops rapidly in the earliest years of life. Children whose parents or other caregivers routinely play with them and talk, sing, and read to them have much better neurological and cognitive development than other children. By providing a biological basis for the importance of human stimulation for children, this research underscores both the significance of interaction and the dangers of social isolation. For both biological and social reasons, socialization is not fully possible without extensive social interaction.

Social-Psychological Explanations: Personality and Cognitive and Moral Development

A second set of explanations is more psychological, as it focuses on the development of personality, cognitive ability, and morality.

Sigmund Freud and the Unconscious Personality

The great psychoanalyst Sigmund Freud (1856–1939) focused on unconscious, biological forces that he felt shape individual personality. Freud (1933)Freud, S. (1933). *New introductory lectures on psycho-analysis*. New York, NY: Norton. thought that the personality consists of three parts: the **id**, **ego**, and **superego**.

- The id is the selfish part of the personality and consists of biological instincts that all babies have, including the need for food and, more generally, the demand for immediate gratification.
- As babies get older, they learn that not all their needs can be immediately satisfied and thus develop the ego, or the rational part of the personality Ego has the knowledge about reality but indifferent about ethics.
- As children get older still, they internalize society's norms and values and thus begin to develop their superego, which represents society's conscience. It has reality and ethics. If a child does not develop normally and the superego does not become strong enough, the individual is more at risk for being driven by the id to commit antisocial behavior.

The Life Course and Transitions

Erikson and Identity Development

We noted earlier that the development of the self is not limited to childhood but instead continues throughout the life span. More generally, although socialization is most important during childhood and adolescence, it, too, continues throughout the life span. Psychologist Erik Erikson (1902–1990) explicitly recognized this central fact in his theory of *identity development* (Erikson, 1980). Erikson, E. H. (1980). *Identity and the life cycle*. New York, NY: Norton. This sort of development, he said, encompasses eight stages of life across the life course. In the first four stages, occurring in succession from birth to age 12, children ideally learn trust, self-control, and independence and also learn how to do tasks whose complexity increases with their age. If all this development goes well, they develop a positive identity, or self-image.

- The fifth stage occurs in adolescence and is especially critical, said Erikson, because teenagers often experience an *identity crisis*. This crisis occurs because adolescence is a transition between childhood and adulthood: adolescents are leaving childhood but have not yet achieved adulthood. As they try to work through all the complexities of adolescence, teenagers may become rebellious at times, but most eventually enter young adulthood with their identities mostly settled. Stages 6, 7, and 8 involve young adulthood, middle adulthood, and late adulthood, respectively. In each of these stages, people's identity development is directly related to their family and work roles. In late adulthood, people reflect on their lives while trying to remain contributing members of society. Stage 8 can be a particularly troubling stage for many people, as they realize their lives are almost over.